

Chapter 148_2 - Three Bows

"Qiu Yi, you..." Jiuying tried several times to get up but found herself powerless despite her will.

Qiu Yi's expression was calm as she half-knelt beside her, her braids woven with colorful ribbons falling across her chest, her features casting shadows.

The pretense just now was merely to blame her drunkenness for all the words she usually didn't dare say.

"Master's Divine Immortal Drunk¹ is indeed useful - even she herself cannot detect or resist it," she said softly. "Jiuying, let me tell you a story."

Jiuying's eyelashes trembled continuously. She tried to call Ning Fuyi's name in her mind, but there was no response from that direction. With all the disciples busy with the barrier, no one would come to this secluded bamboo grove.

"Once upon a time there was a country called Cangyun Kingdom. It had abundant water and grass, warm winters and cool summers - a rich and peaceful place where the people lived in contentment with no wars."

"But no one knew that Cangyun Kingdom's territory once belonged to the most ancient branch of the human race - the Jiuli Tribe². The Jiuli Tribe, entrusted by the Divine Race, promised to guard a Nuwa Empress artifact for generations."

"That is, the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle."

The moment these five words appeared, Jiuying's eyes widened in shock, her fingertips moving slightly.

Wind blew down another bamboo leaf, spinning as it fell, each one bathed in moonlight.

Accompanied by the whistling wind, Qiu Yi carefully removed a leaf from Jiuying's hair and continued: "Cangyun Kingdom thought it would live forever with this secret, never imagining that one day a natural disaster would descend, killing millions of people and turning the prosperous land into hell."

"The world thought this was done by the demon race, but never imagined that what truly caused Cangyun Kingdom's destruction was actually the immortals that the people worshipped daily."

Qiu Yi smiled, seeming to have long accepted the absurdity of this fact.

"That is, Penglai."

Jiuying couldn't even blink now, only immersed in shock.

"Penglai somehow learned of the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle and forced the Jiuli Tribe - that is, Cangyun Kingdom's imperial lineage - to hand over the artifact. However, they would rather die than submit, refusing no matter what to reveal the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle's whereabouts, which brought the disaster of national destruction."

"At that time, the Human Emperor and Empress had just given birth to a daughter. To protect the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle and to protect their infant daughter, they placed the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle inside the child and hid her in a secret place. With the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle's protection, this girl was able to survive."

"That girl is me," Qiu Yi said gently, then smiled. "Otherwise, how could the architecture of the mortal realm protect a child?"

Jiuying kept staring as Qiu Yi's eyes turned toward the sky, gazing at the deep blue night.

"So I am the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle you've all been searching for. The Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle is hidden within one of my souls, undiscovered by anyone, including myself."

"Only when I died once and Master reconstructed my body from my soul did it allow me to remember all of this," Qiu Yi said, pointing to her mind.

"So I've come to say goodbye," Qiu Yi said.

Jiuying closed her eyes, turned her face to the side to hide the tear about to flow into her hair, then she too soon entered dreamland.

Qiu Yi's smile faded, tears glistening in her eyes. Wind kept blowing, chilling her spine. She slowly reached toward the face that looked delicate as porcelain under moonlight, but her fingertips trembled for a moment before she ultimately didn't dare touch it.

"Goodbye, Qi Jiuying," she withdrew her hand.

Then she stood up, flinging her braids behind her and striding through the wind toward the mountain peak - the highest cliff of Cloud Ascension Mountain, now verdant with green grass.

Moonlight broke through thick clouds, drilling a hole to spill onto the earth. Mountains and rivers were bright as snow.

Qiu Yi straightened her back and thrust the twin blades that had accompanied her for many years into the ground at her feet. Suddenly she turned around, swept her robes and knelt toward Jingshan Palace's direction, smiling through tears as she bowed heavily three times.

"First bow - unforgettable master's grace."

"Second bow - toward what the heart desires."

"Third bow - to all living beings across the four seas, may they live ten thousand years!"

1. **Divine Immortal Drunk (神仙醉)** - A powerful intoxicating substance or drug that can affect even immortals
2. **Jiuli Tribe (九黎族)** - In Chinese mythology, an ancient tribe led by the legendary leader Chiyao, often portrayed as opponents of the Yellow Emperor